Socially, Japanese youth are widely reported to be dissatisfied with their future prospects, and the scope for individualism in the workplace remains tightly constricted. Foreigners are tolerated but not particularly welcomed, and Japanese of Korean descent still face discrimination. Immigration is all but absent. Moreover, Japan has faced its own homegrown terrorists, like the millennial Aum Shinrikyo cult, which set off a deadly toxin attack on Tokyo subways in 1995. Above all, the country faces a debilitating demographic collapse, one no modern democracy has ever encountered and which poses the single greatest threat to Japan's future.

Yet compared with the problems that both the West and many of its neighbors face, Japan's relative strength and stability should at the least cause us to rethink our assumptions about social and economic policy. The *Wall Street Journal*'s Jacob Schlesinger argued that, for two decades after the popping of the bubble, Japan's leadership consciously chose a deflationary course for the economy, seeking stability and a minimization of the social risk that would accompany radical economic restructuring.[7] Only the return of Shinzo Abe to the premiership in 2012 reversed this long trend, as he actively sought to modestly inflate the economy, privileging economic expansion over stability. The difference might be thought of as "value" policy versus "growth" policy, similar to stocks or mutual funds. The careful, moderate reforms of what is called "Abenomics" indicate that even the current government is seeking a mix of value and growth, again prioritizing social stability.

Despite decades of officially slow or stagnant macro growth, the real economic picture of Japan is better than many Westerners think. Writing in the *Financial Times*, Matthew C. Klein showed that, in the decade from 2005 to 2014, real GDP per person grew more in Japan than in the United States, Great Britain, and the Eurozone.[8] In the almost quarter century from 1990 to 2013, nearly the entire post-bubble era, real household consumption in Japan also grew more than in the Eurozone, lagging behind only Great Britain, the United States, and Sweden.